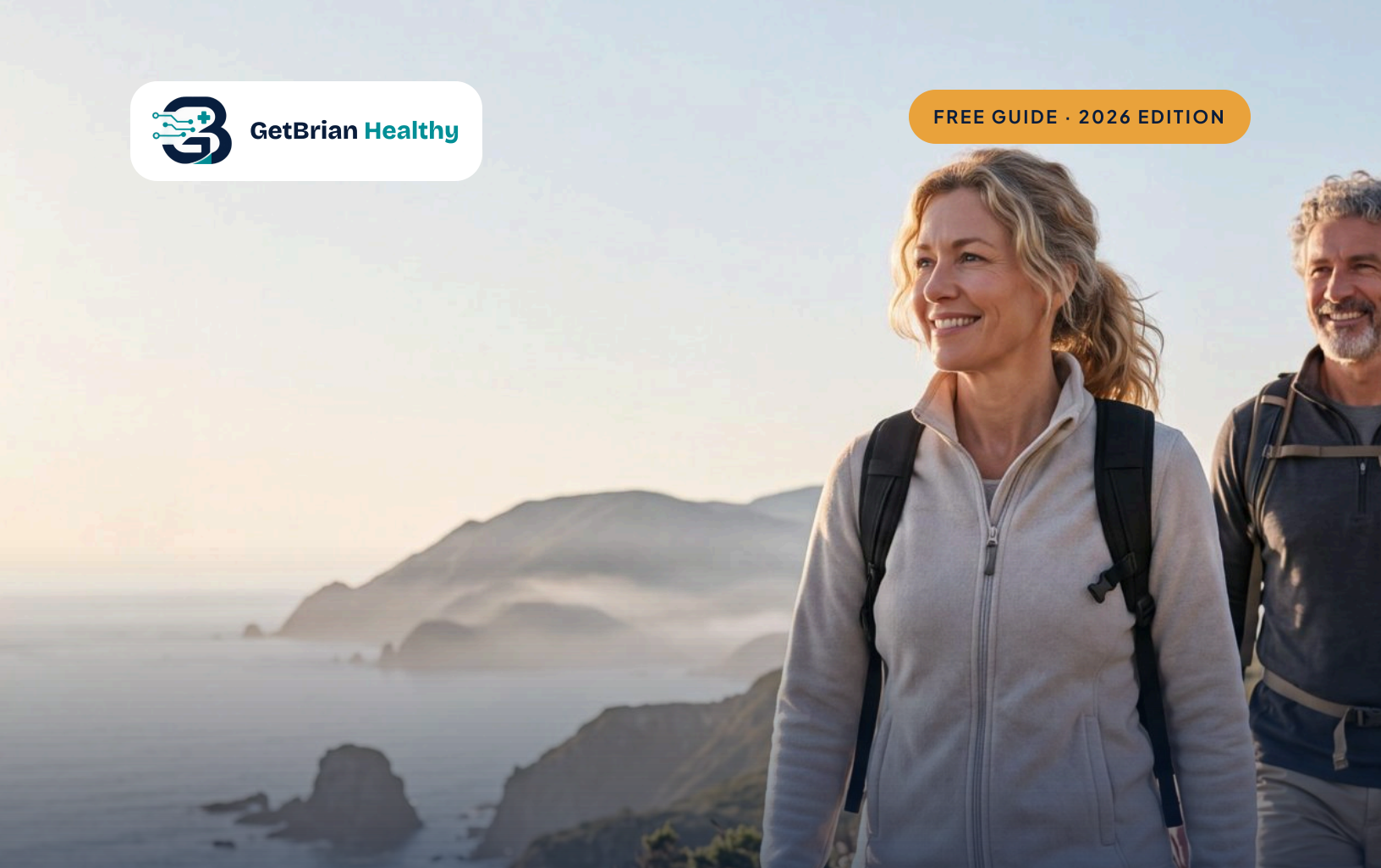
GetBrian Healthy

FREE GUIDE · 2026 EDITION



THE EVIDENCE-CHECKED GUIDE FOR ADULTS 40+

Energy. Strength. Calm.

What the clinical research really says about magnesium, creatine and L-theanine, plus the food, training and sleep habits that do most of the work.

18
peer-reviewed papers

3
labels audited

7
day starter plan



Researched, graded and signed off by Brian at **getbrianhealthy.xyz**

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

Three goals. One honest method.

01	**A note from Brian** Why this guide exists	3
02	**How Brian audits a supplement** The four checks every pick must pass	4
03	**Energy** Magnesium, food first, then the label	5
04	**Strength** Creatine, lifting and protein after 40	8
05	**Calm** L-theanine, breathing and sleep	11
06	**Your 7-day starter plan**	14
07	**The evidence scorecard**	15
08	**Safety first**	16
09	**References** Every source, with a link you can check	18

How to read the grades

Every claim in this guide carries one of three grades. The grade tells you how much weight the research can hold.

ROBUST

Consistent results across several randomized trials or meta-analyses.

PROMISING

Supportive trials exist, but results vary or the groups studied were narrow.

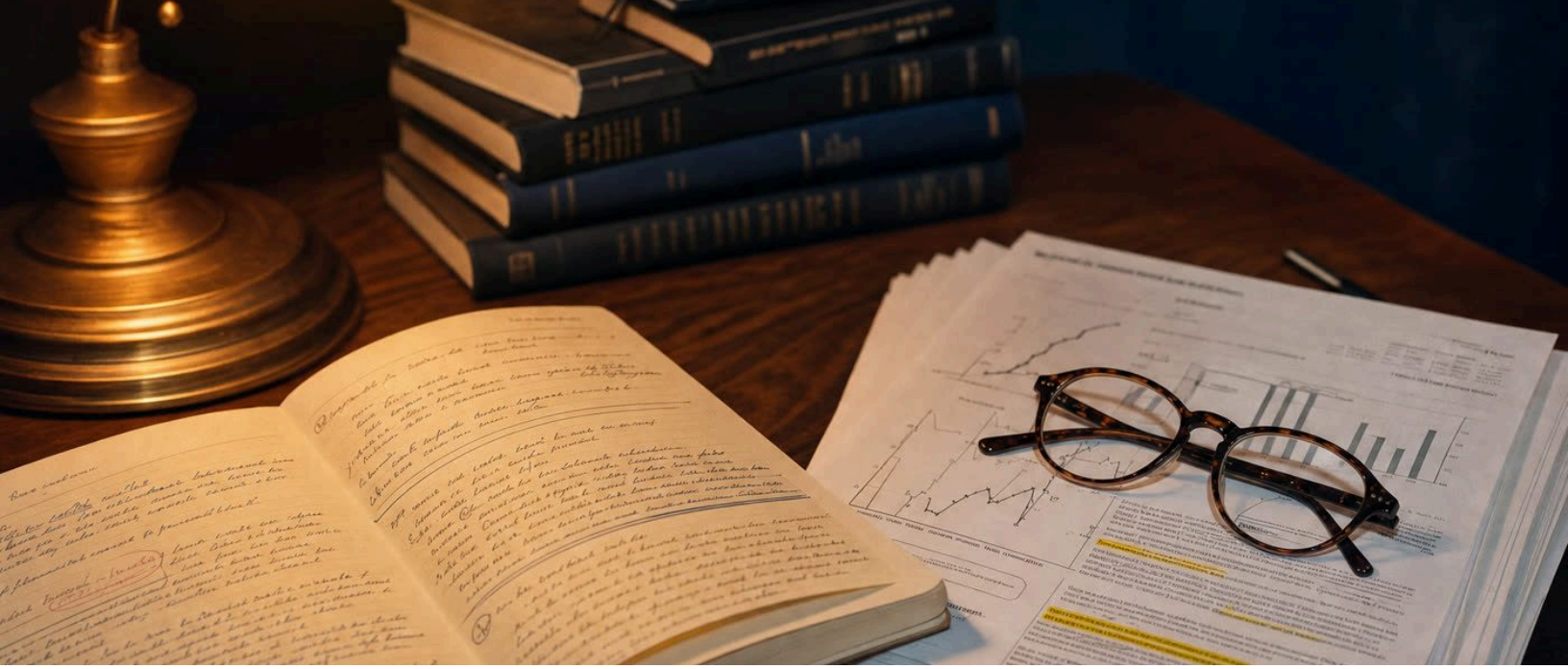
EARLY

Small, short or mixed studies. Worth watching, not worth relying on.

Small numbers like this[6] point to the full reference on pages 18 and 19. Each one has a DOI or link, so you can read the original yourself.



"Skip to the goal you care about most. Each chapter stands on its own."



01 · A NOTE FROM BRIAN

Most supplement advice skips the boring part. I don't.

You have probably seen the reels. A tub, a smile, and the words "clinically proven". What you rarely see is the trial behind it, the dose that trial used, and whether the tub in the video holds that dose.

That gap is what I check. For each ingredient in this guide I read the systematic reviews and randomized trials first. Then I hold a real product label up against them: the form, the dose, the testing and the safety notes. If the label does not match the research, it does not make my list.

You will also find things here that most supplement guides leave out: where the evidence is thin, where a placebo did just as well, and the habits that matter more than any capsule. Food, training and sleep come first. Supplements fill gaps.

Brian

Who is Brian?

Brian is the voice of GetBrian. The research behind each review is gathered and summarized with the help of AI tools, then checked and signed off by Clifton Flack, who founded GetBrian. Brian is not a doctor, and this guide is not medical advice.

Three promises

- No "clinically proven". Every claim gets a plain grade.
- No brand pays to be included.
- Every pick is re-checked at least every six months.

How Brian audits a supplement

In the US, supplements do not need FDA approval before they go on sale.[20] So the work of checking falls to you, or to someone you trust to do it properly. Here is exactly what I check.

1 — Research
Reviews and trials first. Each claim gets a plain grade.

2 — Label vs trial
Same form? Same dose? No blends that hide amounts.

3 — Testing
Independent marks, such as NSF. If none, I say so plainly.

4 — Safety + cost
Upper limits, drug interactions, cost per serving.

Only products that pass all four checks make the list. One pick per ingredient.

Why "label vs trial" matters most

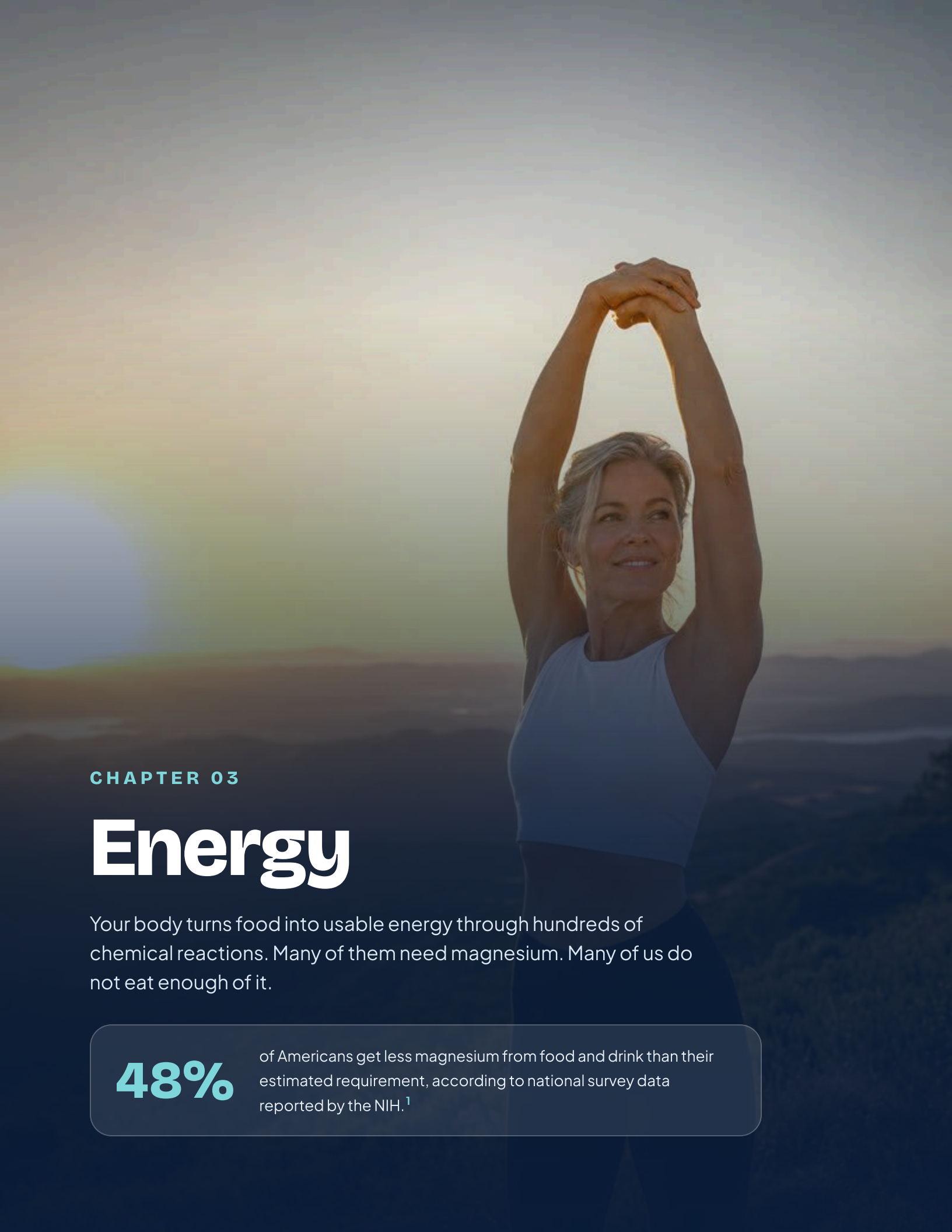
A trial tests one form of an ingredient at one dose. A product can use a cheaper form, a smaller dose, or hide the amount inside a "proprietary blend". Then the trial no longer tells you much about that product.

So my first question for any label is simple: **would this product have qualified for the trial?**

Three red flags on any label

- **"Proprietary blend"** with no amount for each ingredient.
- **A dose far below the studied range**, often to fit many ingredients into one capsule.
- **Disease words** such as "cures", "treats" or "prevents". Supplements may not claim these in the US.





CHAPTER 03

Energy

Your body turns food into usable energy through hundreds of chemical reactions. Many of them need magnesium. Many of us do not eat enough of it.

48% of Americans get less magnesium from food and drink than their estimated requirement, according to national survey data reported by the NIH.[1]

The mineral behind 300+ enzyme systems

The NIH Office of Dietary Supplements describes magnesium as a cofactor in more than 300 enzyme systems, and states it is required for energy production.[1] It also supports normal muscle and nerve function. Researchers have even called it an "orphan nutrient", because it gets far less attention than calcium.[2]

Older adults are more likely to fall short. They tend to eat less magnesium, absorb less from the gut and lose more through the kidneys.[1]

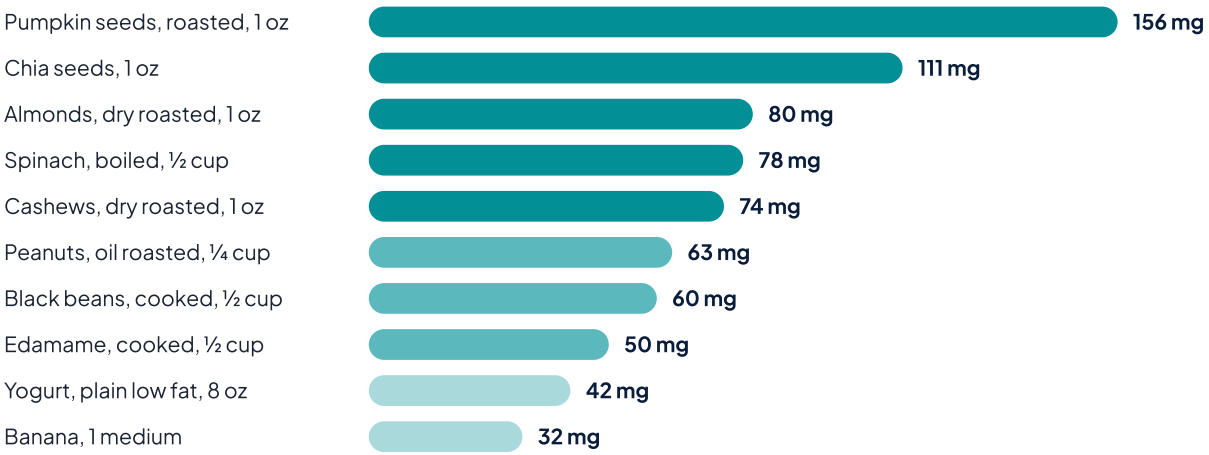
ROBUST Magnesium supports normal energy metabolism and muscle function.[1]

How much do you need a day?

AGE	MEN	WOMEN
31 to 50	**420 mg**	**320 mg**
51+	**420 mg**	**320 mg**

Recommended Dietary Allowance, from all sources.[1] Separately, the upper limit for magnesium **from supplements** is 350 mg a day for adults.[1]

Food first: the best sources per serving



Source: NIH ODS Table 2, magnesium content of selected foods.[1]

374 mg

One easy day, from food alone: a handful of pumpkin seeds on breakfast yogurt (156 mg), a handful of almonds as a snack (80 mg), and spinach with black beans at dinner (78 + 60 mg). That is more than a woman's daily target, before any supplement.

Magnesium and sleep: an honest look

Tired days often start with poor nights, so sleep is where many people first try magnesium. The research is small and mixed. Here are two trials in older adults, side by side.

EARLY

The encouraging trial

46 older adults with insomnia took 500 mg of magnesium or a placebo for 8 weeks. The magnesium group reported better insomnia scores, better sleep efficiency and faster sleep onset.[3]

Brian's note: 500 mg is above the 350 mg upper limit for supplements. Do not copy this dose without your doctor.

EARLY

The sobering trial

100 adults aged 51 to 85 with poor sleep took 320 mg of magnesium citrate or a placebo for 7 weeks. Sleep scores improved a lot, from 10.4 to 6.6, **but by the same amount on placebo**. So the trial could not show that magnesium caused the change.[4]

> **"A placebo that works just as well is not a reason to buy anything."**
>
> Brian, on reading trial results

The takeaway: magnesium's best-supported job is the basic one. It helps cover a common gap in the diet that your energy metabolism and muscles depend on. Better sleep is a possible bonus, not a promise.

Which form?

Forms that dissolve well tend to be absorbed better than magnesium oxide. The NIH lists carbonate, chloride, gluconate and oxide as the forms most often linked to diarrhea.[1] Glycinate is not on that list.

Brian's pick · Pure Encapsulations Magnesium Glycinate

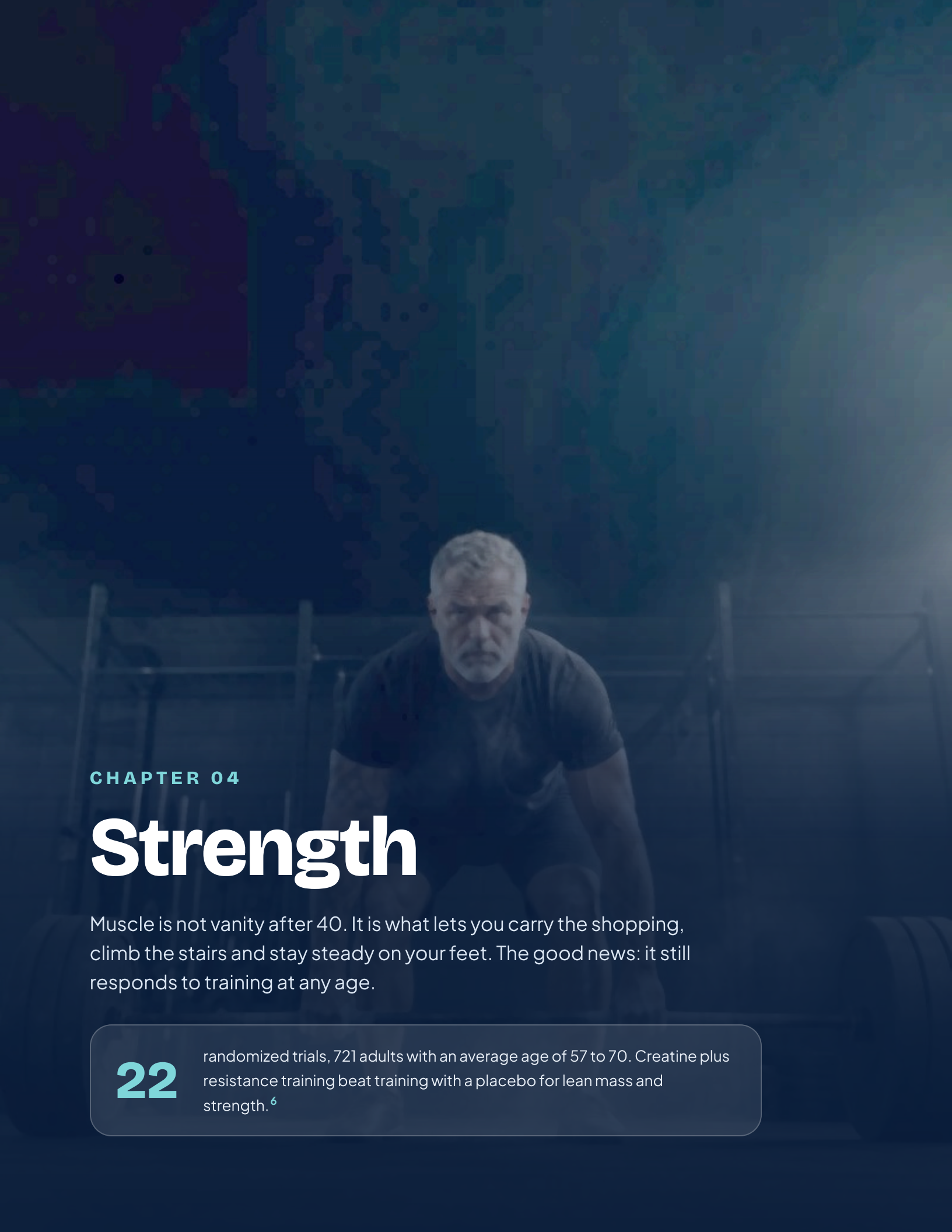
LABEL AUDIT



- ✓ **Single ingredient.** Magnesium as glycinate, no blend, so the label is easy to check.
- ✓ **120 mg a capsule.** Build up one capsule at a time and stay under the 350 mg supplemental upper limit.
- ✓ **Gentler form.** Not one of the forms the NIH lists as most linked to diarrhea.
- ! **Honest minus:** costs more per milligram than bulk powder, and Brian found no independent certification mark.

See the full review and today's price →

These statements have not been evaluated by the Food and Drug Administration. This product is not intended to diagnose, treat, cure, or prevent any disease.



CHAPTER 04

Strength

Muscle is not vanity after 40. It is what lets you carry the shopping, climb the stairs and stay steady on your feet. The good news: it still responds to training at any age.

22 randomized trials, 721 adults with an average age of 57 to 70. Creatine plus resistance training beat training with a placebo for lean mass and strength.[6]

Lift, eat enough protein, then add creatine

1. Train your muscles twice a week

The World Health Organization's 2020 guidelines recommend 150 to 300 minutes of moderate activity a week for adults, plus regular muscle-strengthening activity.[11] Their headline message is a kind one:

> **"Some physical activity is better than none."**
>
> WHO Guideline Development Group, 2020[11]

- Two sessions a week of squats, push-ups, rows and carries.
- Pick a weight you can lift 8 to 12 times with good form.
- Add a little weight or one more rep when it starts to feel easy.

2. Eat more protein than you think

An expert group on protein and ageing (PROT-AGE) recommends at least 1.0 to 1.2 g of protein per kg of body weight a day for people over 65, and more for those who exercise.[12]

A meta-analysis of 49 trials found that extra protein boosted strength gains from training. Gains in lean mass leveled off at about 1.6 g per kg a day.[13]

Quick math

At 75 kg (165 lb), 1.2 g per kg is **90 g of protein a day**. That is about 30 g at each meal: three eggs and a yogurt, a chicken breast, or a can of tuna with a cup of beans.

3. What creatine added in the trials

+1.37 kg
more lean tissue mass
than training with a placebo
(95% CI 0.97 to 1.76 kg)

Chest ↑
greater chest-press gain
standardized effect 0.35
(small to moderate)

Legs ↑
greater leg-press gain
standardized effect 0.24
(small)

Chilibeck et al., 2017: meta-analysis of 22 randomized trials, 721 older adults training 2 to 3 days a week for 7 to 52 weeks.[6]

ROBUST

What the experts say about creatine

Creatine is one of the most studied supplements there is. Two expert reviews from the International Society of Sports Nutrition answer most of the questions people ask.[8,9]

YOU MAY HAVE HEARD	WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS
"You need a loading phase."	No. A steady 3 to 5 g a day fills your muscles too. It just takes a few weeks longer.[9]
"It harms your kidneys."	In healthy people, the ISSN position stand reports long-term use as safe and well tolerated, including up to 30 g a day for 5 years.[8] If you have kidney disease, ask your doctor first.
"It is just water weight."	Early weight gain of a pound or two can be water held in muscle. The trials above also measured lean tissue gains alongside training.[6,9]
"It is only for young athletes."	The expert panel looked at this question directly, and the meta-analyses in older adults show benefits when creatine is paired with training.[6,7,9]
"It sharpens your brain."	● PROMISING A review of 6 trials found possible gains in short-term memory and reasoning, but conflicting results elsewhere. Promising, not proven.[10]

The honest catch: creatine works *with* training, not instead of it. One meta-analysis found that the size of the strength benefit depended on how creatine was taken, and some effects shrank when loading-phase studies were left out.[7] Lift first. Then let creatine help the work count.

Brian's pick · Pure Encapsulations Creatine Monohydrate

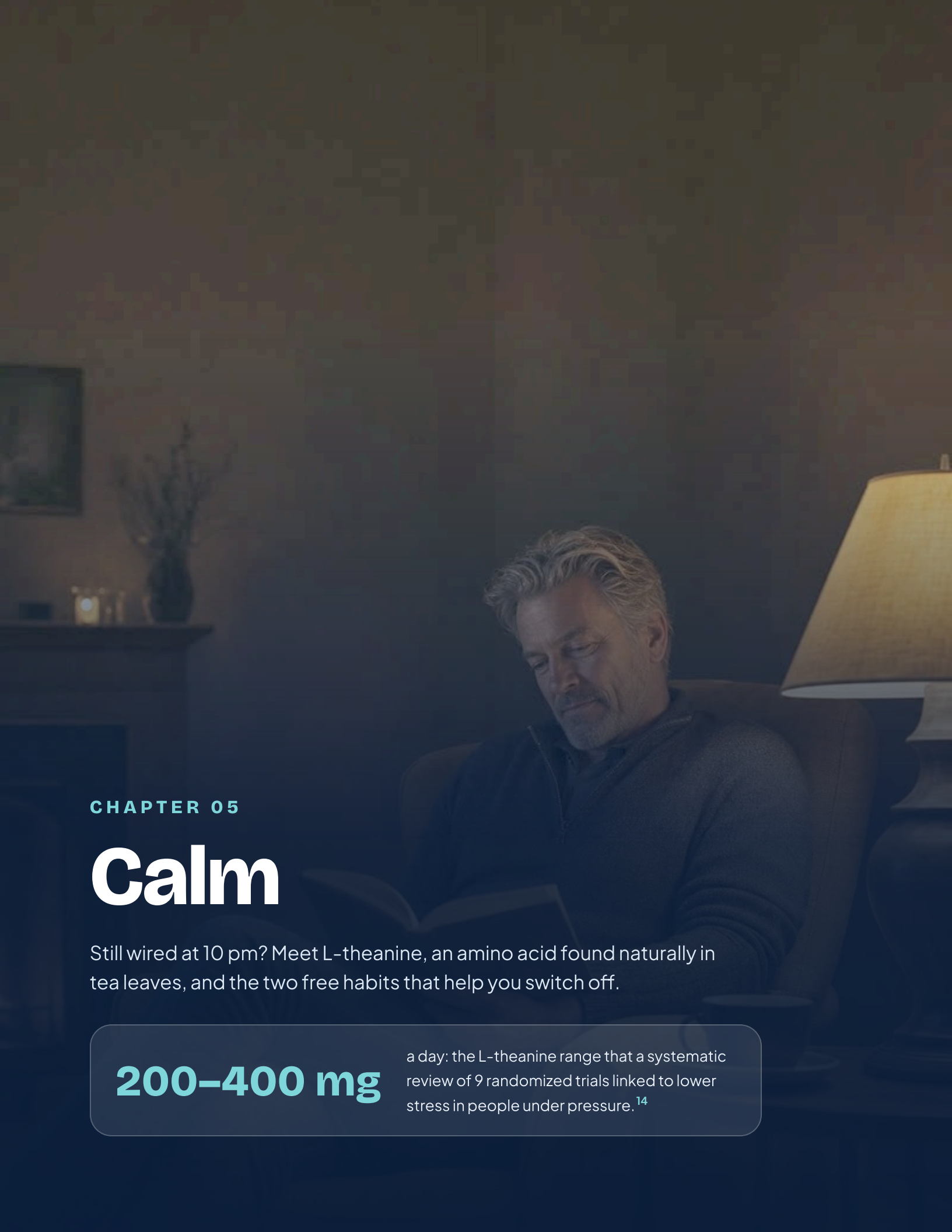
LABEL AUDIT



- ✓ **The studied form.** Plain creatine monohydrate, the form used in the trials.
- ✓ **The studied dose.** 5 g a serving, inside the 3 to 5 g a day the experts recommend.[9]
- ✓ **Nothing added.** No sugars, flavors or blends to dilute the dose.
- ! **Honest minus:** no independent certification mark found. Tested athletes should pick an NSF Certified for Sport product.

See the full review and today's price →

These statements have not been evaluated by the Food and Drug Administration. This product is not intended to diagnose, treat, cure, or prevent any disease.



CHAPTER 05

Calm

Still wired at 10 pm? Meet L-theanine, an amino acid found naturally in tea leaves, and the two free habits that help you switch off.

200–400 mg a day: the L-theanine range that a systematic review of 9 randomized trials linked to lower stress in people under pressure.[14]

Four studies, from biggest picture to smallest

Not all studies weigh the same. A review that pools many trials sits at the top. A single small trial sits lower. Here is the L-theanine research, in that order.

PROMISING

Systematic review
9 randomized trials

Lower stress under pressure

200 to 400 mg a day of L-theanine may help reduce stress and anxiety in people exposed to stressful conditions. The authors call for larger and longer trials before it is relied on.[14]

EARLY

Randomized trial
30 adults, 4 weeks

Better sleep-quality scores

Healthy adults took 200 mg a day or a placebo. On L-theanine, stress-related scores fell, and sleep scores for time to fall asleep and sleep disturbance improved compared with placebo.[17]

EARLY

Crossover trial
34 adults

Less stress during a hard task

One hour after an L-theanine drink, people reported less stress during a multitasking challenge than after placebo. Their cortisol response to the stressor was lower three hours after the dose.[16]

EARLY

Lab trial
12 adults

A calmer heart under stress

During a mental arithmetic test, L-theanine reduced the rise in heart rate compared with placebo.[15]

> **Brian's verdict: a promising, gentle tool for stressful days. Not a sedative, and not a fix for chronic anxiety.**



These statements have not been evaluated by the Food and Drug Administration. This product is not intended to diagnose, treat, cure, or prevent any disease.

Slow your breath. Protect your sleep.

The 5-minute slow-breathing reset

A systematic review found that slow breathing, under 10 breaths a minute, is linked to higher heart-rate variability and calmer brain activity in healthy people.[18]



- Sit, and put one hand on your belly.
- Breathe in through your nose for 4 seconds.
- Breathe out slowly for 6 seconds.
- Repeat for 5 minutes. That is 6 breaths a minute.

Aim for 7 hours or more

The American Academy of Sleep Medicine and the Sleep Research Society agree that adults should sleep 7 or more hours a night on a regular basis.[19]

- Same wake-up time every day, weekends too.
- Caffeine before noon only.
- Screens off 30 minutes before bed. Read instead.
- Cool, dark, quiet bedroom.

And magnesium for stress? A review of 18 studies found the evidence suggestive but of poor quality.[5] So we do not lean on it for calm.

Brian's pick · Pure Encapsulations L-Theanine

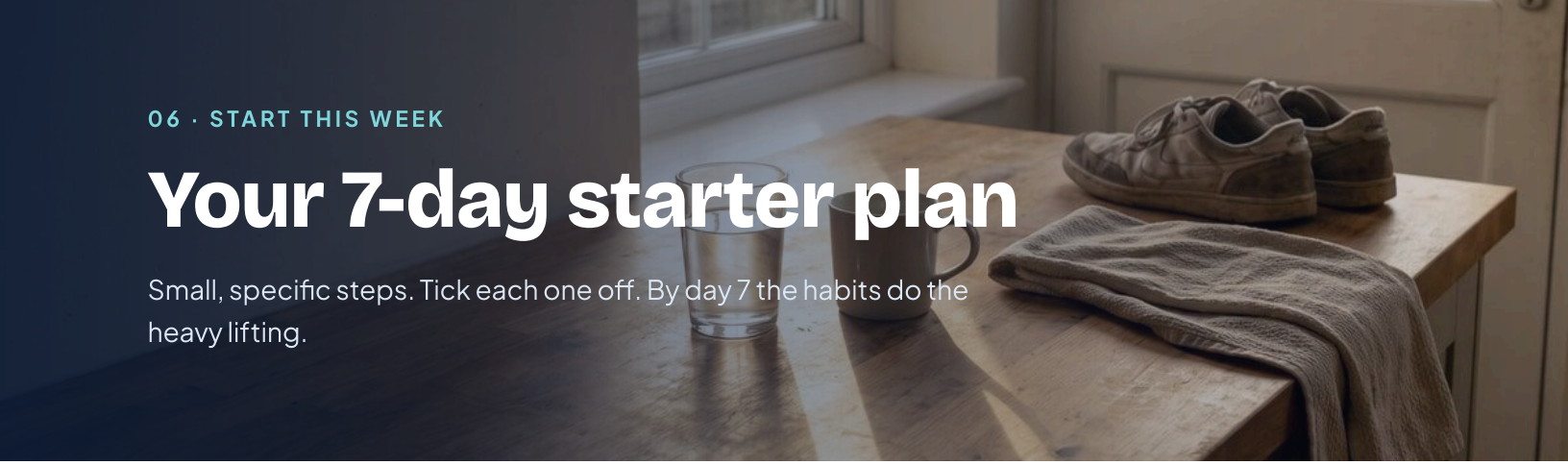
LABEL AUDIT



- ✓ **The studied dose.** 200 mg a capsule, inside the 200 to 400 mg a day range from the trials.[14]
- ✓ **A named, purified form.** Suntheanine is printed on the label.
- ✓ **Single ingredient.** No blend, so you know exactly what you take.
- ! **Honest minus:** costs more per capsule than generic L-theanine. The two-capsule serving (400 mg) is the top of the studied range, so many people start with one.

See the full review and today's price →

These statements have not been evaluated by the Food and Drug Administration. This product is not intended to diagnose, treat, cure, or prevent any disease.



06 · START THIS WEEK

Your 7-day starter plan

Small, specific steps. Tick each one off. By day 7 the habits do the heavy lifting.

DAY	ENERGY	STRENGTH	CALM
1	☐ Add pumpkin seeds or almonds to breakfast	☐ 10 squats, 10 wall push-ups	☐ 5 minutes of slow breathing
2	☐ Spinach or beans with dinner	☐ Protein at breakfast (about 30 g)	☐ Set one fixed wake-up time
3	☐ Check your food against the 320 / 420 mg target	☐ First full session: squats, push-ups, rows, carries	☐ Last coffee before noon
4	☐ A 20–minute brisk walk	☐ Protein at every meal	☐ Screens off 30 min before bed
5	☐ Read one supplement label with the 3 red flags	☐ Second session, add 1 rep each	☐ 5 minutes of slow breathing
6	☐ Another 20–minute walk	☐ Ask your doctor if creatine suits you	☐ 7+ hours in bed, lights out
7	☐ **Review the week.** Which goal matters most to you? Read Brian's full review for that one pick, and only add a supplement to fill a real gap.		

Want it on your fridge?

Brian's printable daily routine sheet is free at getbrianhealthy.xyz/routine

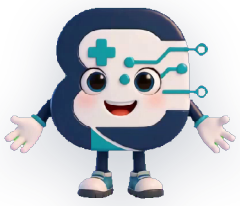
One goal at a time. Each ingredient in this guide has research behind it on its own. Taking all three together has not been shown to work better than any one alone, or to extend lifespan. Most people only need the one that matches their goal.

07 · AT A GLANCE

The evidence scorecard

Every claim in this guide on one page, with its grade and its key source. Screenshot it for your next trip to the store.

INGREDIENT	CLAIM	GRADE	KEY SOURCE
Magnesium	Supports normal energy metabolism and muscle function	ROBUST	NIH ODS fact sheet[1]
Magnesium	May support sleep quality when intake is low	EARLY	Abbasi 2012; Nielsen 2011[3,4]
Magnesium	May ease feelings of stress or anxiety	EARLY	Boyle 2017, poor-quality evidence[5]
Creatine	Supports strength with resistance training	ROBUST	Chilibeck 2017, 22 RCTs[6]
Creatine	Supports lean muscle mass with training	PROMISING	Forbes 2021[7]
Creatine	Safe and well tolerated in healthy people	ROBUST	ISSN position stand 2017[8]
Creatine	May support short-term memory	PROMISING	Avgerinos 2018, 6 RCTs[10]
L-theanine	May support relaxation under everyday stress	PROMISING	Williams 2020, 9 RCTs[14]
L-theanine	May support sleep quality	EARLY	Hidese 2019, 30 adults[17]
Habits	Muscle-strengthening activity for all adults	ROBUST	WHO 2020 guidelines[11]
Habits	7+ hours of sleep a night	ROBUST	AASM / SRS consensus[19]
Habits	Slow breathing for a calmer body	PROMISING	Zaccaro 2018[18]



These statements have not been evaluated by the Food and Drug Administration. These products are not intended to diagnose, treat, cure, or prevent any disease.

Safety first

Supplements are not risk-free. Talk to your doctor or pharmacist before you start one, especially if any of these apply to you.

Magnesium

- Do not take it if you have kidney disease, unless your doctor advises it.[1]
- Keep supplements to 350 mg a day or less unless a doctor says otherwise.[1]
- Take it at least 2 hours apart from osteoporosis drugs (bisphosphonates), and apart from some antibiotics. Ask your pharmacist for timing.[1]
- Long-term diuretics and acid reflux drugs (PPIs) can change your magnesium levels.[1]

Creatine

- Talk to your doctor first if you have kidney disease or take medication that affects the kidneys.
- A pound or two of early weight gain is common. It is water in muscle, not fat.[9]
- Stick to 3 to 5 g a day unless advised otherwise.[9]

L-theanine

- Generally well tolerated.
- Talk to your doctor before you combine it with blood pressure medication. It may add to a lowering effect.
- Interactions with sedatives have not been ruled out. Check with a pharmacist.

Also talk to your doctor first if you

- are pregnant or breastfeeding
- take any prescription medicine
- have a long-term health condition
- are preparing for surgery
- feel tired all the time for no clear reason. Fatigue can have medical causes worth checking.

This guide is general information, not a diagnosis or personal medical advice. Food supplements should not replace a varied, balanced diet and a healthy lifestyle.





YOUR NEXT STEP

One goal. One pick. Checked for you.

Brian's site shows the single pick that best matched its studied dose, label and price, for the country you live in. Full reviews, honest minuses and the sources behind every claim.

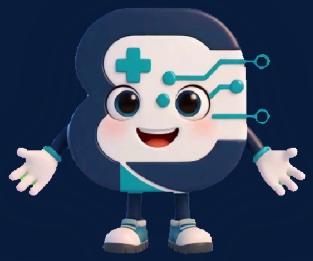
See Brian's current picks →

How Brian picks

Watch your inbox
One short, evidence-checked tip a week. No spam.

Re-checked picks
We tell you when a pick changes, and why.

Ask Brian
Reply to any email with your question.



As an Amazon Associate I earn from qualifying purchases. The Buy buttons on getbrianhealthy.xyz go to Amazon, and GetBrian may be paid a commission at no extra cost to you. Commission never decides which products are listed or how they are graded. These statements have not been evaluated by the Food and Drug Administration. These products are not intended to diagnose, treat, cure, or prevent any disease.

09 · SOURCES

References

Every source was checked against PubMed or the publisher's page in November 2026. Read any of them at the DOI link.

1. NIH Office of Dietary Supplements. Magnesium: Fact Sheet for Health Professionals. Updated 6 January 2026. ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Magnesium-HealthProfessional
2. Rosanoff A, Weaver CM, Rude RK. Suboptimal magnesium status in the United States: are the health consequences underestimated? *Nutr Rev*. 2012;70(3):153–64. doi:10.1111/j.1753-4887.2011.00465.x
3. Abbasi B, Kimiagar M, Sadeghniiat K, et al. The effect of magnesium supplementation on primary insomnia in elderly: a double-blind placebo-controlled clinical trial. *J Res Med Sci*. 2012;17(12):1161–9. PMID 23853635
4. Nielsen FH, Johnson LK, Zeng H. Magnesium supplementation improves indicators of low magnesium status and inflammatory stress in adults older than 51 years with poor quality sleep. *Magnes Res*. 2010;23(4):158–68 (published online 2011).doi:10.1684/mrh.2010.0220
5. Boyle NB, Lawton C, Dye L. The effects of magnesium supplementation on subjective anxiety and stress: a systematic review. *Nutrients*. 2017;9(5):429. doi:10.3390/nu9050429
6. Chilibeck PD, Kaviani M, Candow DG, Zello GA. Effect of creatine supplementation during resistance training on lean tissue mass and muscular strength in older adults: a meta-analysis. *Open Access J Sports Med*. 2017;8:213–226. doi:10.2147/OAJSM.S123529
7. Forbes SC, Candow DG, Ostojic SM, Roberts MD, Chilibeck PD. Meta-analysis examining the importance of creatine ingestion strategies on lean tissue mass and strength in older adults. *Nutrients*. 2021;13(6):1912. doi:10.3390/nu13061912
8. Kreider RB, Kalman DS, Antonio J, et al. International Society of Sports Nutrition position stand: safety and efficacy of creatine supplementation in exercise, sport, and medicine. *J Int Soc Sports Nutr*. 2017;14:18. doi:10.1186/s12970-017-0173-z
9. Antonio J, Candow DG, Forbes SC, et al. Common questions and misconceptions about creatine supplementation: what does the scientific evidence really show? *J Int Soc Sports Nutr*. 2021;18(1):13. doi:10.1186/s12970-021-00412-w
10. Avgerinos KI, Spyrou N, Bougioukas KI, Kapogiannis D. Effects of creatine supplementation on cognitive function of healthy individuals: a systematic review of randomized controlled trials. *Exp Gerontol*. 2018;108:166–173. doi:10.1016/j.exger.2018.04.013

11. Bull FC, Al-Ansari SS, Biddle S, et al. World Health Organization 2020 guidelines on physical activity and sedentary behaviour. *Br J Sports Med*. 2020;54(24):1451–1462. doi:10.1136/bjsports-2020-102955
12. Bauer J, Biolo G, Cederholm T, et al. Evidence-based recommendations for optimal dietary protein intake in older people: a position paper from the PROT-AGE Study Group. *J Am Med Dir Assoc*. 2013;14(8):542–59. doi:10.1016/j.jamda.2013.05.021
13. Morton RW, Murphy KT, McKellar SR, et al. A systematic review, meta-analysis and meta-regression of the effect of protein supplementation on resistance training-induced gains in muscle mass and strength in healthy adults. *Br J Sports Med*. 2018;52(6):376–384. doi:10.1136/bjsports-2017-097608
14. Williams JL, Everett JM, D'Cunha NM, et al. The effects of green tea amino acid L-theanine consumption on the ability to manage stress and anxiety levels: a systematic review. *Plant Foods Hum Nutr*. 2020;75(1):12–23. doi:10.1007/s11130-019-00771-5
15. Kimura K, Ozeki M, Juneja LR, Ohira H. L-Theanine reduces psychological and physiological stress responses. *Biol Psychol*. 2007;74(1):39–45. doi:10.1016/j.biopsycho.2006.06.006
16. White DJ, de Klerk S, Woods W, et al. Anti-stress, behavioural and magnetoencephalography effects of an L-theanine-based nutrient drink: a randomised, double-blind, placebo-controlled, crossover trial. *Nutrients*. 2016;8(1):53. doi:10.3390/nu8010053
17. Hidese S, Ogawa S, Ota M, et al. Effects of L-theanine administration on stress-related symptoms and cognitive functions in healthy adults: a randomized controlled trial. *Nutrients*. 2019;11(10):2362. doi:10.3390/nu11102362
18. Zaccaro A, Piarulli A, Laurino M, et al. How breath-control can change your life: a systematic review on psycho-physiological correlates of slow breathing. *Front Hum Neurosci*. 2018;12:353. doi:10.3389/fnhum.2018.00353
19. Watson NF, Badr MS, Belenky G, et al. Recommended amount of sleep for a healthy adult: a joint consensus statement of the American Academy of Sleep Medicine and Sleep Research Society. *Sleep*. 2015;38(6):843–4. doi:10.5665/sleep.4716
20. U.S. Food and Drug Administration. Dietary Supplements. fda.gov/food/dietary-supplements

About this guide

Energy. Strength. Calm. is published by GetBrian Healthy (getbrianhealthy.xyz), contact healthy@getbrian.xyz. US edition, November 2026. Product label details were last reviewed on 1 October 2026 from retailer listings. Labels and prices change, so check the current label before you buy.

© 2026 GetBrian. You may share this PDF freely in its complete, unchanged form.